

Alberta professors cite free expression in defending lecturer who called Holodomor a hoax



University of Alberta students protest after an assistant lecturer posted Facebook comments denying the Holodomor was an act of genocide, in Edmonton, Dec. 2, 2019. *Ed Kaiser/Postmedia*

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EDMONTON — A coalition of academics at the University of Alberta is coming to the defence of a lecturer who declared in a Facebook post that the Holodomor famine was a hoax spread by fascists, which led to widespread condemnation and calls for his resignation from the students' union and other groups.

"The learning environment is not ... made 'safe' when any individual or group attempts to prevent another's exercise of freedom of expression," the letter says. "It is fundamentally undermined, as the ability to examine, analyze, and critique all ideas is the lifeblood of the university."



Doug MacDonal ran for the Marxist-Leninist Party of Canada in the recent federal election. *Kevan Hunter*

The signatories of the letter, released earlier this week, were responding to a statement made Nov. 28 by Akanksha Bhatnagar, the student union president [that called upon Doug MacDonal](#) to take back his Holodomor remarks "or resign," and requested the university condemn his comments.

Akanksha Bhatnagar, the president of the Students' Union, told the Post she stands entirely behind the statement they've made, and won't be changing it. "This is the right thing to do," she said. "At some point you have to be able to define truth and this is an undeniable fact."

The [Dec. 2 letter](#) from the 43 academics across the university's faculties and departments says MacDonald's comments are protected by university principles of free expression.

The academics were joined, as well, [in a separate statement](#) from Kevin Kane, the president of the Association of Academic Staff, on Dec. 1, which said Bhatnagar's statement "can be seen as pressure for retroactive self-censorship."

"This is inconsistent with principles of freedom of expression."

Kane did not respond to a request for comment.

The controversy began in November, when Dougal MacDonald, a lecturer in the faculty of education and former candidate for the Marxist-Leninist Party, called Holodomor a myth, and wrote that "in Canada, former Nazi collaborators and their spawn have long led the phony (sic) Holodomor campaign."

The post was first reported by The Gateway, and that led to condemnation from the Ukrainian Students' Society, which implored in a Facebook statement that people contact the university to ensure "Dougal MacDonald is no longer allowed to share such messages." The Ukrainian Canadian Congress [is also calling](#) for the "immediate censure and termination" of MacDonald for his statements and the Jewish Federation of Edmonton condemned it, too.

"It is irresponsible and deeply dishonest to suggest that the Holodomor didn't happen. This type of revisionism is dangerous, and we object to it in the strongest terms."

Holodomor refers to a period in the early 1930s in Ukraine, when agricultural collectivization under Joseph Stalin's Communist government in the Soviet Union led to millions of deaths by starvation.

“Free and public debate on issues, especially controversial issues, is a healthy aspect of our society and is, in fact, necessary, if we are to make any progress toward building a better future,” wrote MacDonald in a follow-up statement. The Post could not reach MacDonald Friday.

The university was unable to offer anyone for an interview Friday, but referred the Post to a statement put online Friday morning that said while MacDonald’s got the right to free expression, “his views do not represent and are not endorsed by the University of Alberta.” The statement said the university would launch a handful of initiatives to increase “awareness and learning about Holodomor on our campus and beyond.”

Bhatnagar calls the initiatives taken by the university steps in the right direction. “The university’s in a tough spot because this is something that was on a personal Facebook page of a professor,” she said.

Denial of Holodomor received staunch criticism from Alberta Premier Jason Kenney, who condemned “Western, supposedly-progressive voices who were complicit in one of history’s great cover-ups.”

“These were the useful idiots of whom Lenin wrote. Westerners who purposefully lied about one of the great acts of mass murder in human history,” said Kenney.

Around 60 people also attended a protest on Tuesday evening.

— *With files from the National Post and Edmonton Journal*

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